At one stage, Modi had hoped that Jayalalithaa, too, would join his team, but she wanted to be the captain herself. With limited options, the BJP plumped for actor-turned-politician Vijayakanth as the chief prop for an alliance in Tamil Nadu. Vijayakanth's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) was a typical example of a New Age small regional party, available, we were told, to the highest bidder. These parties are often one-person shows with small but well-defined pockets of influence that enable them to bargain with larger parties from a position of relative strength. Vijayakanth, for example, had won around 10 per cent votes in the 2009 Lok Sabha elections, enough to make him a potential 'swing' factor. 'He will negotiate with everyone and then will go with whoever gives him the best money deal,' is how one Tamil journalist explained Vijayakanth's politics.

The BJP was a minor force in Tamil Nadu. It had won just seven seats from the state in fifteen previous Lok Sabha elections. But that didn't stop Modi from addressing major rallies in Chennai. Or from meeting Tamil superstar Rajinikanth in April 2014, just ahead of polling in the state. The meeting was projected as a courtesy call but was obviously much more than that. Rajinikanth described Modi as a 'strong leader' and a 'good friend'. 'The Rajini–Modi photo op may not have given us extra votes in Tamil Nadu, but we were able to send out a message across the country that even the most popular face of south India was effectively endorsing him,' claims a BJP strategist.

The pan-India appeal was what Modi was constantly seeking. Speaking to him a few days after the Tamil Nadu alliance was sealed, I sensed that he saw an enlarged NDA as crucial to his self-image as a genuine 'national' leader. '*Yeh political punditon ko lagta tha ki koi hamein join nahin karega . . . ki Modi untouchable hai. Ab yeh kya kahenge?*' (Political pundits thought no one would join us, that Modi is an untouchable. Now, what will they say?), he said to me on one of our calls. Modi will not concede it, but he had been anguished by his years of political 'isolation'; now, he finally felt politically 'acceptable' and his rehabilitation was tinged with pique.